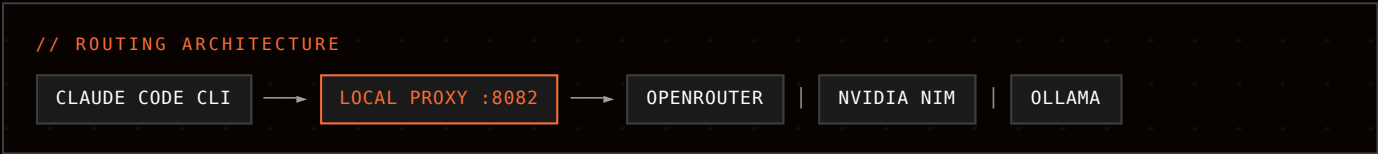


// SETUP-GUIDE.001

Run Claude Code For Free.

A step-by-step guide to wiring up Claude Code's agentic CLI against ultra-low-cost proxies or a fully local model. Five phases. Three options. Zero billing surprises.



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// PHASES

05 / FIVE

// BACKEND OPTIONS

03 / A · B · C

// COST FLOOR

\$0.00 / FREE

SECTION 01 — INSTALL & PAID OPTION

// PHASE-01

Clone & install the proxy repo

Get the routing layer onto your machine before touching any keys.

- 01

Open your terminal window.

SHELL
- 02

Run the install commands listed in the `free-claude-code` GitHub quick start to pull dependencies.

INSTALL
- 03

Execute the `git clone` command from the guide to download the repo locally.

CLONE
- 04

Change into the new `free-claude-code` directory.

CD
- 05

In Finder, hit `⌘ + Shift + .` to reveal the hidden `.env` file inside the project folder.

REVEAL

OPT A — OpenRouter (paid, ultra-low cost)

PHASE-02

- 01

Open `openrouter.ai` and log into your account.

AUTH
- 02

Create a new API key, name it, and copy the generated key right away.

KEY
- 03

Open the hidden `.env` in a text editor.

EDIT
- 04

Paste the key into the `OPENROUTER_API_KEY` placeholder line.

PASTE
- 05

Back on OpenRouter's model browser, copy your model string (e.g. `deepseek/deepseekv4-flash`) and paste it into the model config block.

MODEL

SECTION 02 — FREE CLOUD & FULLY LOCAL

OPT B — NVIDIA NIM (free cloud models)

PHASE-03 · FREE

- 01

Sign up or log into the NVIDIA NIM platform.

AUTH
- 02

Click "Generate API Key", name it, and copy the resulting string.

KEY
- 03

Open `.env` and paste the token into the Nvidia API key placeholder.

PASTE
- 04

Find the model config block and insert your free model string, e.g. `nvidia-nim/z-ai/glm-4.7`.

MODEL
- 05

Save the file with `⌘ + S`.

SAVE

OPT C — Ollama (100% free, fully local)

PHASE-04 · LOCAL

- 01

Install Ollama from `ollama.com` via browser or terminal one-liner.

INSTALL
- 02

Run `ollama pull gemma:4` (or your preferred model) to download the ~10GB weights.

PULL
- 03

Open `.env` and confirm the Ollama base URL matches your local port, usually `http://localhost:11434`.

VERIFY
- 04

Add your model name under the local provider section, prefixed as `ollama/gemma:4-latest`, then save.

CONFIG

SECTION 03 — LAUNCH SEQUENCE

// PHASE-05

Boot the proxy & route Claude Code

Final stretch. Bind the proxy, override the base URL, start prompting.

- 01

In your primary terminal, confirm you're still inside the `free-claude-code` root.

PWD
- 02

Run the proxy init command (`npm run start` or the repo's step-3 start command) to bind it to local port `8082` .

START
- 03

Open a brand new secondary terminal tab.

NEW TAB
- 04

Paste & execute the Claude Code bash init command that overrides the Anthropic base URL to `http://localhost:8082` .

OVERRIDE
- 05

Turn off "fast mode" inside Claude Code if you hit compatibility errors with your backend model.

DEBUG
- 06

Type your prompts exactly like you would in standard Claude Code. You're live.

SHIP



// COHORT-08 • ENROLLMENT OPEN

You wired up Claude Code. Now **ship**.

Cohort 8 is the next intake of the 100xEngineers applied AI program — diffusion, full-stack LLMs, agents, and the production engineering that makes them ship.

12

// WEEKS

04

// PILLARS

100+

// PROJECTS

1:1

// MENTORSHIP

// CORE MODULES

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// WHAT YOU'LL SHIP

- A portfolio of production-grade AI projects
- Deep fluency across diffusion, LLMs, and agents
- Direct intros into the 100x hiring partner network

// READY TO BUILD?

Apply for Cohort 8 →**100XENGINEERS.COM**